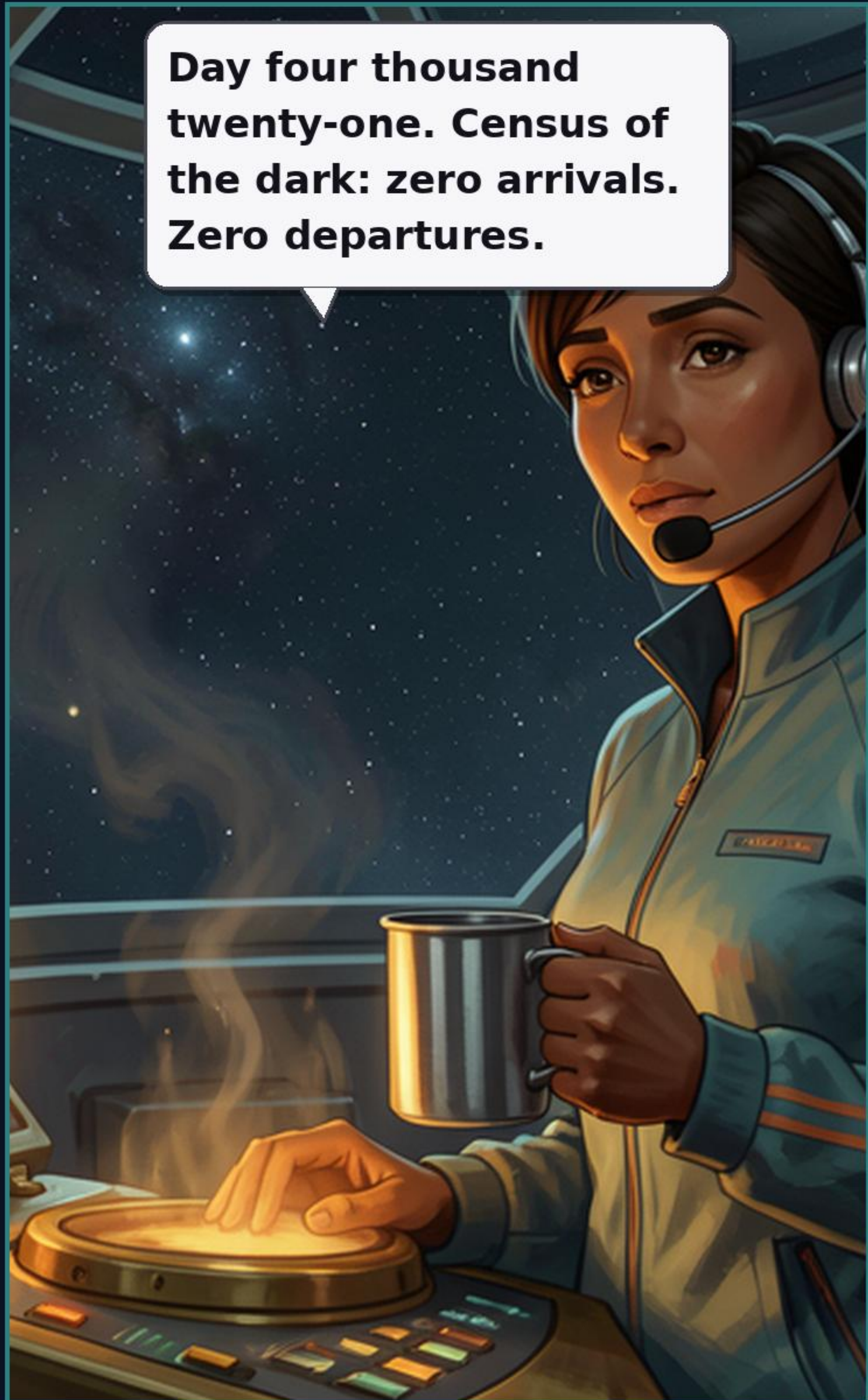




THE QUIET BEACON

A 4-PAGE SCI-FI SHORT

STATION CARYS — EDGE OF EVERYTHING MAPPED. POPULATION: ONE.



**Day four thousand
twenty-one. Census of
the dark: zero arrivals.
Zero departures.**



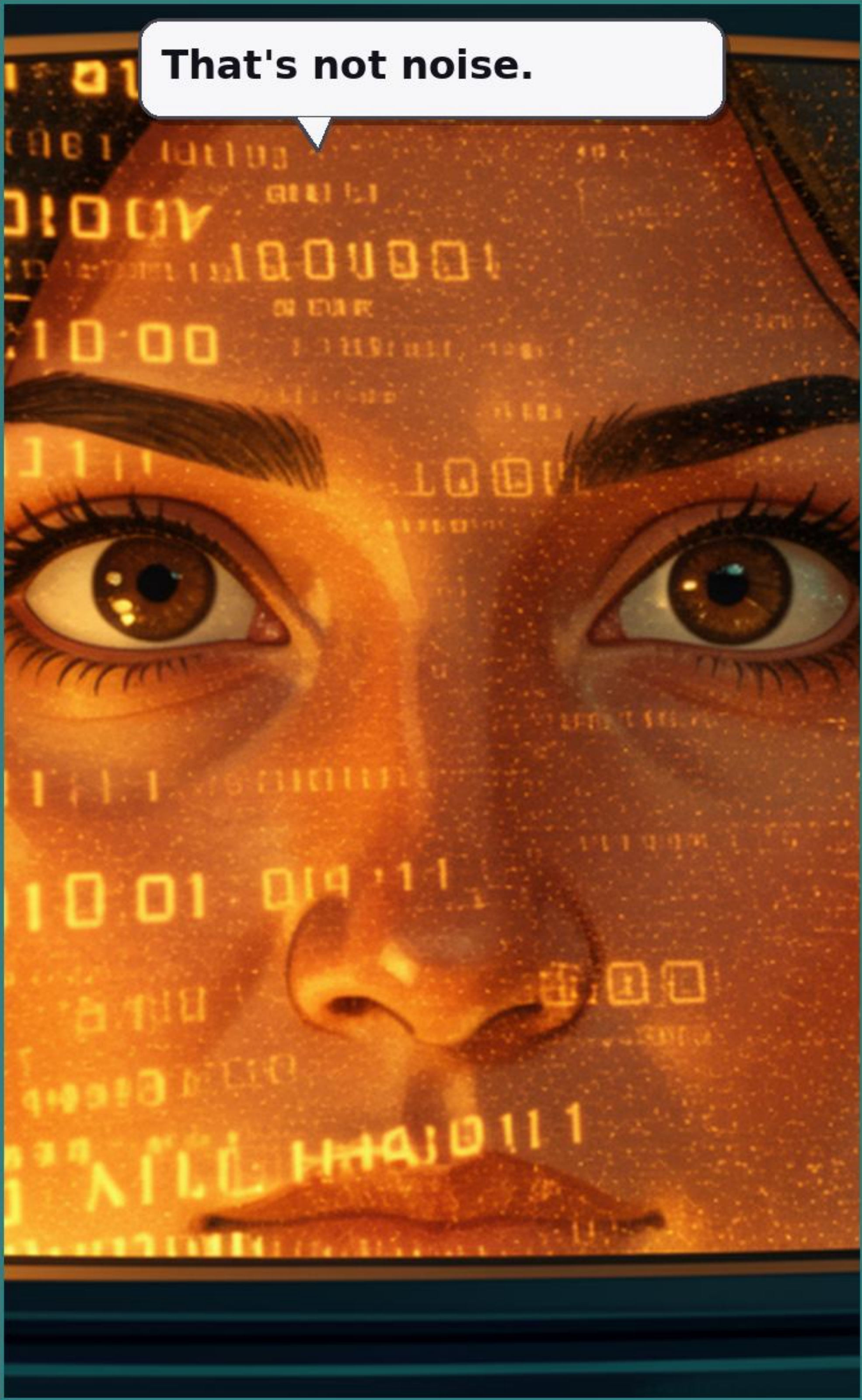
Every day, the same silence. Every day,
she sends it anyway.



Eleven years of routine. The beacon, the core, the wait.



Then, a blip that answers no known ship.



That's not noise.

This is Carys. Identify.



And from the dark, a light begins to answer.



Someone was still out there. Someone who remembered how to listen.



The beacon flares for the first time in years.



Day four thousand twenty-two. Census of the dark: one arrival. The listening continues.